

Wigner Resolution from Action Capacity

Brian S. Mulloy 

Independent Researcher, Corktown, Detroit, Michigan, USA*

(Dated: 2026-06-26)

The Wigner function represents a quantum state in phase space. Smoothing it gives a non-negative portrait, with the smoothing scale conventionally set from outside the state. We show that the resolution is set by the state. The state's action capacity $\pi \Delta x \Delta p$ fixes a family of de Gosson quantum blobs deforming at constant action $h/2$. Convolving the Wigner function with the kernel of a single $h/2$ blob renders it non-negative for a specific choice of coordinates. Integrating over the family is coordinate-free and resolves the portrait at $\pi \hbar^2 / (\Delta x \Delta p)$, the symplectic polar dual of the capacity. The portrait is everywhere non-negative and holds the structure of the Wigner function in place. Wigner resolution derives from the state's action capacity alone and sharpens as that capacity grows.

The Wigner function represents a quantum state in phase space [1, 2]. It is defined pointwise below Planck's quantum of action, where Hudson's theorem forces it negative [3]. Its negativity is a resource for quantum advantage [4, 5] and a measure of nonclassicality [6]. A non-negative distribution supports classical sampling [7–11] and follows from smoothing the Wigner function at a freely chosen scale. Here the state sets that scale without a free parameter.

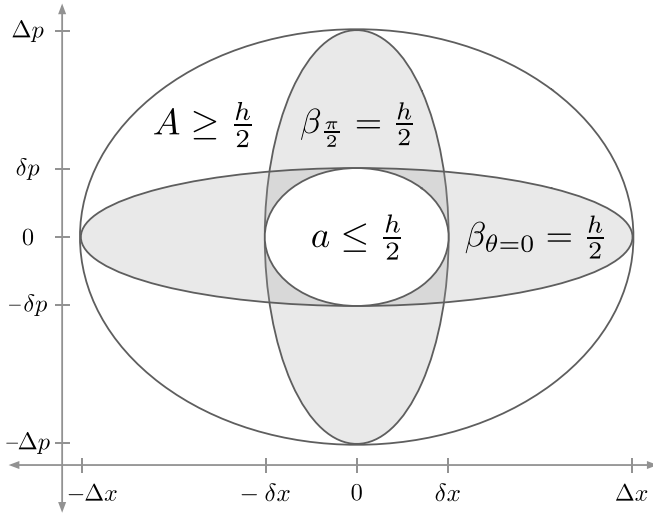


FIG. 1. Capacity, quantum blobs at principal axes, and resolution. The state's covariance ellipsoid has action capacity $A = \pi \Delta x \Delta p \geq h/2$. The quantum blob family (Fig. 2) has two members at the principal axes, $\beta_{\theta=0} = \pi \Delta x \delta p = h/2$ and $\beta_{\pi/2} = \pi \delta x \Delta p = h/2$. The resolution a is an ellipse with semi-axes $\delta x, \delta p$ and action $a = \pi \delta x \delta p = \pi \hbar^2 / (\Delta x \Delta p)$. A circumscribes $\beta_{\theta=0}$ and $\beta_{\pi/2}$, which circumscribe a .

Planck divided phase space into elementary regions of action [12]. Heisenberg's uncertainty principle $\sigma_x \sigma_p \geq \hbar/2$ [13, 14] fixes their minimum area but not their form, which a rotation of the axes redraws [15, 16]. Geometrically, de Gosson replaced this coordinate-dependent tiling [17] with one covariance ellipse per state [18], of semi-axes $\Delta x = \sqrt{2} \sigma_x$ and $\Delta p = \sqrt{2} \sigma_p$. This is the

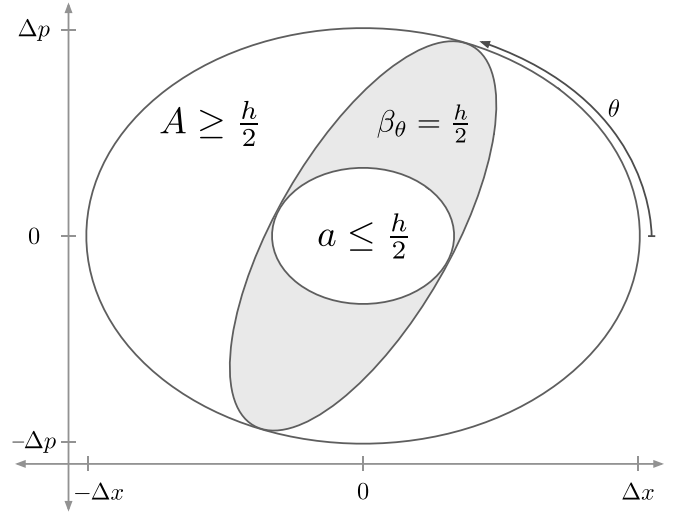


FIG. 2. Capacity, quantum blob family, and resolution. Action capacity A circumscribes the quantum blob family $\{\beta_\theta\}$, which circumscribes resolution a . Across θ the blob family deforms at constant action $\beta_\theta = h/2$. At the principal angles $\theta = 0$ and $\theta = \pi/2$, the family recovers $\beta_{\theta=0}$ and $\beta_{\pi/2}$ from Fig. 1.

action capacity (Figs. 1, 2),

$$A = \pi \Delta x \Delta p \geq h/2. \quad (1)$$

The Wigner function carries structure at small scales. Zurek located those scales, $\delta p \sim \hbar/\Delta x$ and $\delta x \sim \hbar/\Delta p$, from the state's action capacity [19]. We identify them as the principal axes of a family of de Gosson quantum blobs [20] (Fig. 1),

$$\beta_{\theta=0} = \pi \Delta x \delta p = h/2, \quad \beta_{\pi/2} = \pi \delta x \Delta p = h/2. \quad (2)$$

The capacities $\Delta x, \Delta p$ run along the major axes, the resolutions $\delta x, \delta p$ along the minor.

Between these principal members the family $\{\beta_\theta\}$ deforms across $\theta \in [0, \pi)$ at constant action $h/2$ (Fig. 2). Capacity A circumscribes each blob β_θ . In the scaled coordinates $X = x/\Delta x$, $P = p/\Delta p$ every member is the

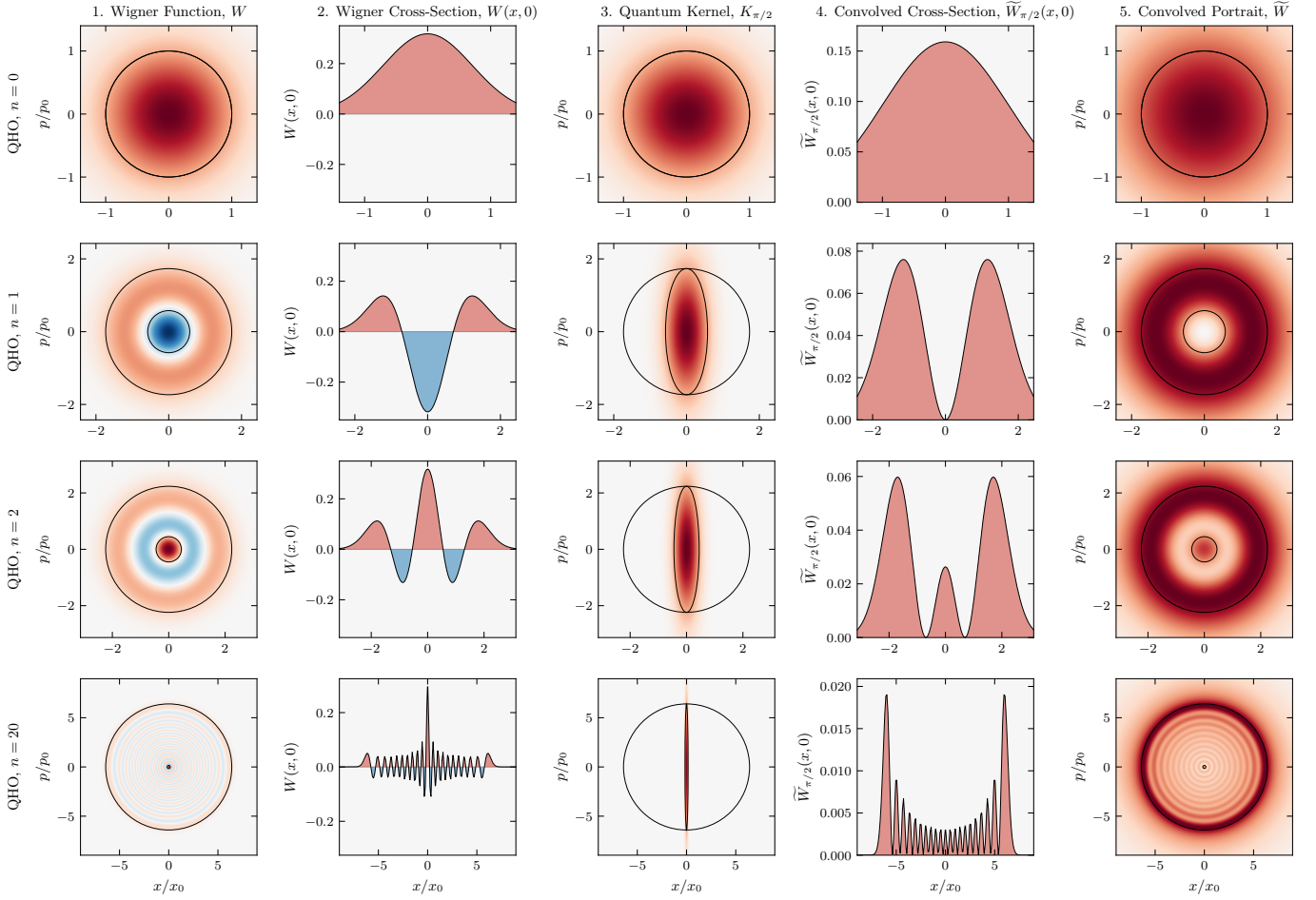


FIG. 3. **Harmonic oscillator.** Rows correspond to Fock states $n = 0, 1, 2, 20$ with action capacity $A/(h/2) = 2n + 1$. Column 1: Wigner function $W(x, p)$ (negativity in blue) overlaid with the capacity A and resolution a . Centered at the covariance origin, a marks the resolution of the finest structure (the Zurek scale) of the bare, unconvolved Wigner function. Column 2: Cross-section $W(x, 0)$ exhibiting negative dips. Column 3: Quantum kernel $K_{\pi/2}$ overlaid with A and the quantum blob $\beta_{\pi/2}$ (action $h/2$, restoring Planck's quantum of action). Column 4: Convolved cross-section $\tilde{W}_{\pi/2}(x, 0)$ at quadrature angle $\theta = \pi/2$, which is non-negative. Column 5: The portrait $\tilde{W}(x, p)$, integrated over the blob family across all θ , overlaid with A and a (symplectic polar duals). It is everywhere non-negative, with positive lobes at the positions of those in W , resolved at a . For the vacuum ($n = 0$), A and a coincide as a Gaussian blob at $A = h/2$. As n increases, A grows and a reciprocally shrinks ($aA = (h/2)^2$). At $n = 20$, the rings condense toward a classical energy trajectory, leaving a as a fine central ellipse. Axes are in the oscillator scales $x_0 = \sqrt{\hbar/m\omega}$ and $p_0 = \sqrt{\hbar m\omega}$.

same rigid ellipse rotated through θ ,

$$\beta_\theta = \left\{ (x, p) : X_\theta^2 + \frac{A^2}{(\pi\hbar)^2} P_\theta^2 \leq 1 \right\}, \quad (3)$$

inscribed in the unit disk. The quadratures $X_\theta = X \cos \theta + P \sin \theta$ and $P_\theta = -X \sin \theta + P \cos \theta$ are those of homodyne tomography at phase θ .

The Wigner function of the state is

$$W(x, p) = \frac{1}{\pi\hbar} \int \psi^*(x+s) \psi(x-s) e^{2ips/\hbar} ds. \quad (4)$$

The quantum kernel K_θ is a pure-state Wigner function, the centered Gaussian whose $h/2$ ellipse is the quantum

blob β_θ ,

$$K_\theta(x, p) = \frac{1}{\pi\hbar} \exp \left[-X_\theta^2 - \frac{A^2}{(\pi\hbar)^2} P_\theta^2 \right]. \quad (5)$$

Convolving W with K_θ ,

$$\tilde{W}_\theta(x, p) = (W * K_\theta)(x, p), \quad (6)$$

lifts W to Planck's quantum of action and renders $\tilde{W}_\theta$ everywhere non-negative [8, 9, 16].

Zurek also located the area scale $a_Z \sim \hbar \times (\hbar/A)$ [19, 21] of the chessboard structure in the compass state (Fig. 4, column 1). We identify its coordinate-free form as the resolution a . It is the ellipse with semi-axes $\delta x, \delta p$

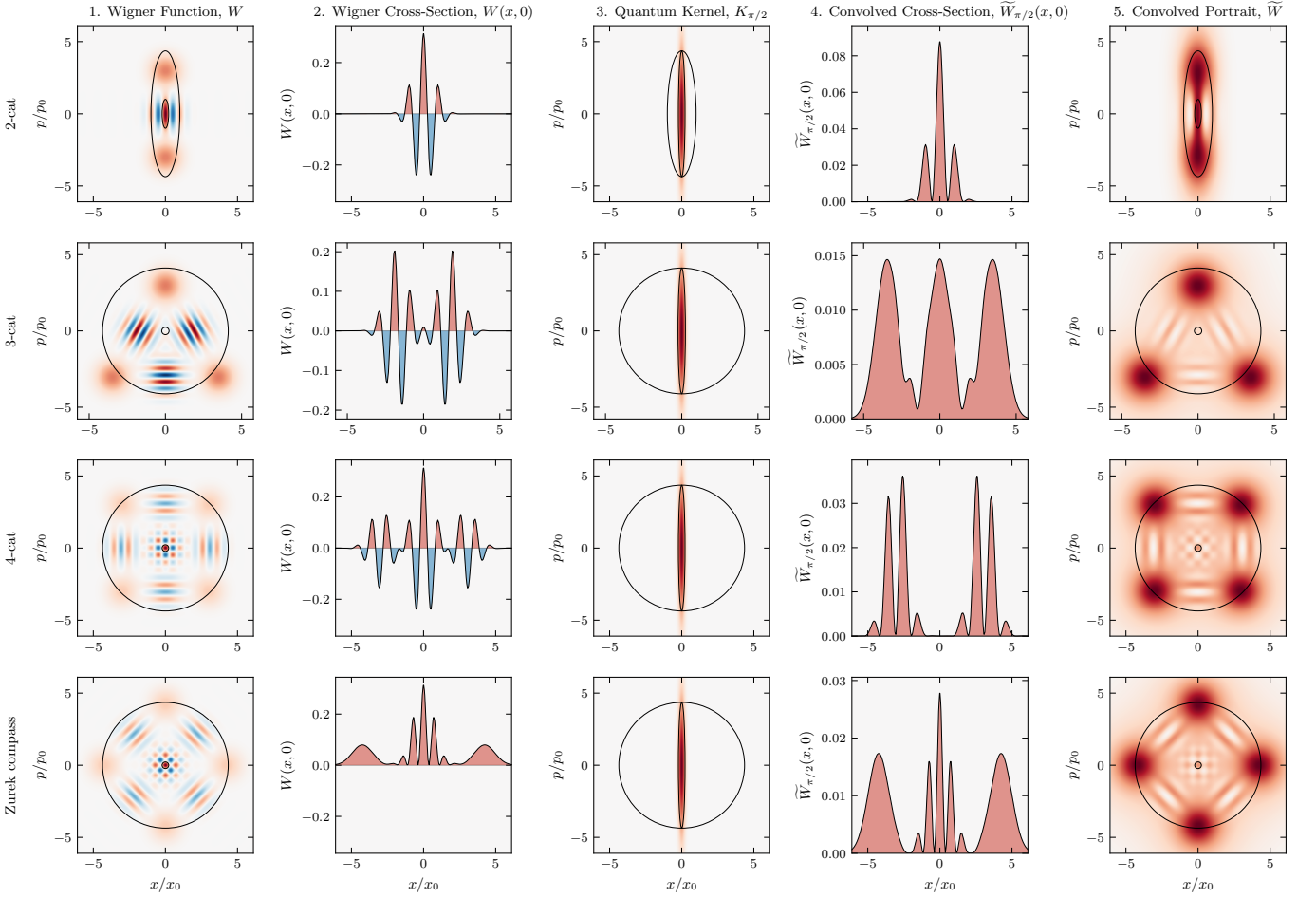


FIG. 4. **Cat states.** Rows correspond to the 2-cat, 3-cat, 4-cat, and Zurek compass states. Columns are as in Fig. 3. As before, the portrait $\widetilde{W}$ (Column 5) is everywhere non-negative, with positive lobes at the positions of those in W , resolved at a . The 4-cat and Zurek compass states differ by a $\pi/4$ rotation in phase space.

(Figs. 1, 2) and action

$$a = \pi \delta x \delta p = \frac{\pi \hbar^2}{\Delta x \Delta p}. \quad (7)$$

It is the resolution of the state's finest structure in the bare Wigner function (Figs. 3, 5, 4, column 1) and the symplectic polar dual of the capacity A [22]. The duality is reflexive, so A and a each fix the other, and antimonotone, so a shrinks as A grows [23]. The capacity A circumscribes each blob β_θ , which circumscribes the resolution a , each β_θ touching a and A twice, with $a \leq \beta_\theta \leq A$ (Fig. 2). Resolution and capacity are reciprocal at the quantum of action, $a A = (\hbar/2)^2$.

A single blob commits to a quadrature, a choice of coordinate the state does not favor. Integrating $\widetilde{W}_\theta$ over the family is coordinate-free, yielding the phase-space portrait,

$$\widetilde{W}(x, p) = \frac{1}{\pi} \int_0^\pi \widetilde{W}_\theta(x, p) d\theta. \quad (8)$$

Each $\widetilde{W}_\theta \geq 0$, so $\widetilde{W} \geq 0$ everywhere. Where standard tomography inverts the marginals to recover the Wigner quasi-probability W [24, 25], convolving W with $\{K_\theta\}$ over the same θ builds the non-negative portrait $\widetilde{W}$.

The convolution and the integral are linear, so the family reduces to a single convolution,

$$\widetilde{W} = W * K, \quad K = \frac{1}{\pi} \int_0^\pi K_\theta d\theta, \quad (9)$$

and the breadth of the kernel's Fourier transform $\widehat{K}$ sets the portrait's resolution. With (ξ_x, ξ_p) the chord conjugate to (x, p) , integrating over θ bounds $\widehat{K}$ above by a single Gaussian,

$$\widehat{K}(\xi_x, \xi_p) \leq \exp\left[-\frac{1}{4}(\delta x^2 \xi_x^2 + \delta p^2 \xi_p^2)\right], \quad (10)$$

with equality at the origin. The bound cuts off at δx and δp , so the portrait carries no structure finer than $\pi \delta x \delta p = a$, derived exactly in the Supplemental Material [26].

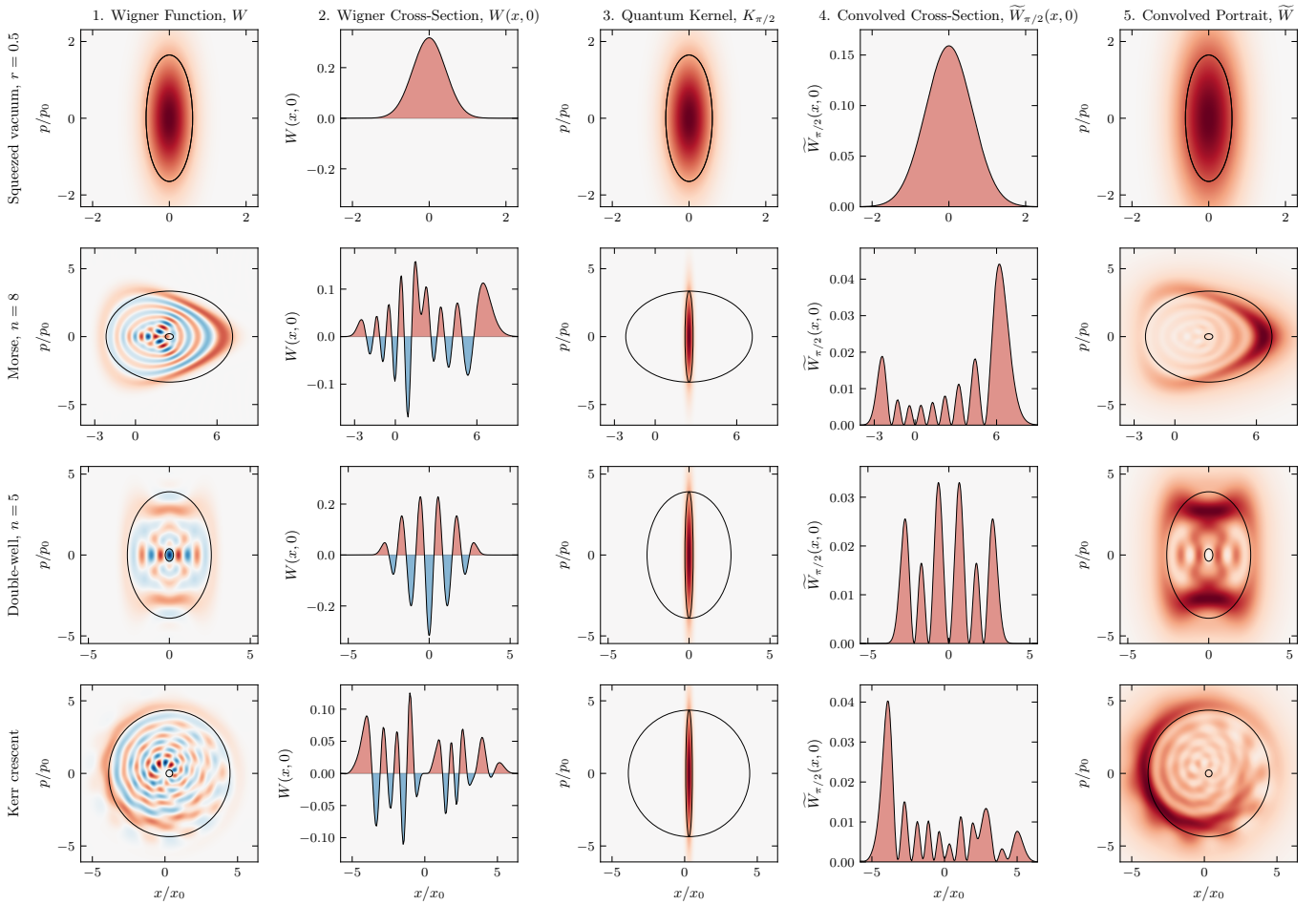


FIG. 5. **Squeezed vacuum, eigenstates, and the Kerr crescent.** Rows correspond to the squeezed vacuum ($r = 0.5$), the Morse eigenstate ($n = 8$), the double-well eigenstate ($n = 5$), and the Kerr crescent, a coherent state sheared at constant photon number. Columns are as in Fig. 3. The Kerr state is shown in the principal frame of its covariance, where the overlays are axis-aligned. The portrait $\tilde{W}$ (Column 5) remains strictly non-negative across all four states, resolved at a .

A quantum blob β_θ too large for A to circumscribe, or too small to circumscribe a , is a blob of another state and portrays that state, not this one [20, 23]. Every $h/2$ blob of this state is inscribed in A and circumscribes a , touching each twice, so no $h/2$ smoothing of this state resolves finer than a , and a kernel below $h/2$ fails to render the portrait non-negative [8, 9]. The finest resolution is a , reached by the family $\{\beta_\theta\}$ across $\theta \in [0, \pi)$.

The principal frame, where A is axis-aligned, costs no generality. The Wigner function transforms covariantly under the symplectic group [16], so the map that diagonalizes a state's covariance carries it to this frame. The Kerr crescent, a sheared coherent state, is resolved this way (Fig. 5). In one degree of freedom, A fixes the family uniquely, and the Zurek structure is already present for states with $A > h/2$. In higher dimensions, action $h/2$ no longer singles out a blob [20], symplectic capacity and volume diverge, and the higher-dimensional case remains for future work.

A fixed vacuum-width Gaussian [7] smooths every

state equally, matching only the vacuum $A = h/2$ and erasing the detail of larger states $A > h/2$. Methods with a free parameter [27–29] resolve more finely, the scale set from outside the state. Here the state sets its own scale. Its action capacity A fixes the resolution a as the symplectic polar dual, with nothing left free.

Figures 3, 4, and 5 show numerical results across twelve states. The portrait $\tilde{W}$ is non-negative to machine precision, the chord-domain transfer carrying W to $\tilde{W}$ follows Eq. (10), and the cross-spectral phase between W and $\tilde{W}$ vanishes. Across every state the portrait $\tilde{W}$ resolves W at a and displaces nothing [26].

The uncertainty product $\sigma_x \sigma_p$ grows unbounded, the micro-to-macro transition Heisenberg [30] and Bohr [31] identified as requiring care. The quantum blob does not. As A grows, the family $\{\beta_\theta\}$ deforms at fixed action $h/2$. Squeezing deforms a state by external apparatus [32]. Here the scale called sub-Planck [19] is the minor axis δ of an $h/2$ blob, narrowing as the conjugate capacity Δp grows. A Schrödinger cat with capacity $\Delta p \sim 1 \text{ kg}\cdot\text{m/s}$

has resolution $\delta x = \hbar/\Delta p \sim 10^{-34}$ m, nineteen orders sub-nuclear [33]. The correspondence principle follows from $A \rightarrow \infty$ and $a \rightarrow 0$, the physical limit underlying the heuristic $\hbar \rightarrow 0$. The resolution sharpens as the action capacity grows, $a = (\hbar/2)^2 / A$. We read this structure as the geometry of phase space itself, which de Gosson finds underlying the uncertainty principle [18].

The author thanks M. de Gosson for helpful comments. This research received no external funding. Computations used QuTiP [34] and SciPy [35]. Code and Supplemental Material are openly available [26].

* bmulloy@umich.edu

- [1] E. Wigner, On the quantum correction for thermodynamic equilibrium, *Physical Review* **40**, 749 (1932).
- [2] M. Hillery, R. F. O’Connell, M. O. Scully, and E. P. Wigner, Distribution functions in physics: Fundamentals, *Physics Reports* **106**, 121 (1984).
- [3] R. L. Hudson, When is the Wigner quasi-probability density non-negative?, *Reports on Mathematical Physics* **6**, 249 (1974).
- [4] V. Veitch, C. Ferrie, D. Gross, and J. Emerson, Negative quasi-probability as a resource for quantum computation, *New Journal of Physics* **14**, 113011 (2012).
- [5] A. Mari and J. Eisert, Positive Wigner functions render classical simulation of quantum computation efficient, *Physical Review Letters* **109**, 230503 (2012).
- [6] A. Kenfack and K. Życzkowski, Negativity of the Wigner function as an indicator of non-classicality, *Journal of Optics B: Quantum and Semiclassical Optics* **6**, 396 (2004).
- [7] K. Husimi, Some formal properties of the density matrix, *Proc. Phys.-Math. Soc. Jpn., 3rd Ser.* **22**, 264 (1940).
- [8] N. D. Cartwright, A non-negative Wigner-type distribution, *Physica A: Statistical Mechanics and its Applications* **83**, 210 (1976).
- [9] M. de Gosson, Cellules quantiques symplectiques et fonctions de Husimi–Wigner, *Bulletin des Sciences Mathématiques* **129**, 211 (2005).
- [10] D. Dragoman, Phase space formulation of quantum mechanics. Insight into the measurement problem, *Phys. Scr.* **72**, 290 (2005).
- [11] A. Polkovnikov, Phase space representation of quantum dynamics, *Annals of Physics* **325**, 1790 (2010).
- [12] M. Planck, *Vorlesungen über die Theorie der Wärmestrahlung* (Johann Ambrosius Barth, Leipzig, 1906) english translation: M. Masius, *The Theory of Heat Radiation* (Blakiston, Philadelphia, 1914).
- [13] E. H. Kennard, Zur Quantenmechanik einfacher Bewegungstypen, *Zeitschrift für Physik* **44**, 326 (1927).
- [14] H. P. Robertson, The uncertainty principle, *Physical Review* **34**, 163 (1929).
- [15] E. Schrödinger, Zum Heisenbergschen Unschärfeprinzip, *Sitzungsber. Preuss. Akad. Wiss., Phys.-Math. Kl.*, 296 (1930).
- [16] E. Cordero, M. de Gosson, M. Dörfler, and F. Nicola, On the symplectic covariance and interferences of time-frequency distributions, *SIAM Journal on Mathematical Analysis* **50**, 2178 (2018).
- [17] M. A. de Gosson, Phase space quantization and the uncertainty principle, *Physics Letters A* **317**, 365 (2003).
- [18] M. de Gosson and F. Luef, Symplectic capacities and the geometry of uncertainty: The irruption of symplectic topology in classical and quantum mechanics, *Phys. Rep.* **484**, 131 (2009).
- [19] W. H. Zurek, Sub-Planck structure in phase space and its relevance for quantum decoherence, *Nature* **412**, 712 (2001).
- [20] M. A. de Gosson, Quantum blobs, *Foundations of Physics* **43**, 440 (2013).
- [21] W. H. Zurek, Decoherence, einselection, and the quantum origins of the classical, *Reviews of Modern Physics* **75**, 715 (2003).
- [22] M. A. de Gosson, Quantum indeterminacy and polar duality, *Mathematical Physics, Analysis and Geometry* **18**, 1 (2015).
- [23] M. de Gosson and C. de Gosson, Symplectic polar duality, quantum blobs, and generalized Gaussians, *Symmetry* **14**, 1890 (2022).
- [24] K. Vogel and H. Risken, Determination of quasiprobability distributions in terms of probability distributions for the rotated quadrature phase, *Physical Review A* **40**, 2847 (1989).
- [25] A. I. Lvovsky and M. G. Raymer, Continuous-variable optical quantum-state tomography, *Reviews of Modern Physics* **81**, 299 (2009).
- [26] B. S. Mulloy, Code, figures, and supplemental material for “Wigner Resolution from Action Capacity” (2026), the supplemental material is archived in this deposit, under the same DOI.
- [27] K. Wódkiewicz, Operational approach to phase-space measurements in quantum mechanics, *Phys. Rev. Lett.* **52**, 1064 (1984).
- [28] D. M. Appleby, Generalized Husimi functions: Analyticity and information content, *J. Mod. Opt.* **46**, 825 (1999).
- [29] K. E. Cahill and R. J. Glauber, Density operators and quasiprobability distributions, *Physical Review* **177**, 1882 (1969).
- [30] W. Heisenberg, The physical content of quantum kinematics and mechanics, in *Quantum Theory and Measurement*, edited by J. A. Wheeler and W. H. Zurek (Princeton University Press, 1983) pp. 62–84.
- [31] N. Bohr, The quantum postulate and the recent development of atomic theory, *Nature* **121**, 580 (1928).
- [32] D. F. Walls, Squeezed states of light, *Nature* **306**, 141 (1983).
- [33] E. Schrödinger, The present situation in quantum mechanics, *Proceedings of the American Philosophical Society* **124**, 323 (1980), translated by J. D. Trimmer from *Naturwissenschaften* **23** (1935) 807–812, 823–828, 844–849.
- [34] N. Lambert *et al.*, QuTiP 5: The quantum toolbox in Python, *Phys. Rep.* **1153**, 1 (2025).
- [35] P. Virtanen *et al.*, SciPy 1.0: Fundamental algorithms for scientific computing in Python, *Nat. Methods* **17**, 261 (2020).